

Midway Progress Report

Team C3: Community Integration

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C4: Cross-Campus Capstone Classroom

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After Action Review

We presented our problem statement and two ideas to four partners: Mike from the Youth Services Bureau, Vanessa from Housing, Infrastructure and Communities Canada, Kay from Trek for Teens, and Robert from Better Street. Feedback was captured live through

collaborative note-taking with key insights highlighted for later synthesis. AI tools (Claude AI, Pro subscription) were used to help organize notes into thematic categories, which were then discussed as a team to identify patterns and make decisions. All four partners validated our problem statement. We framed the core issue as: services exist, community hubs exist, but nothing connects them, leaving people experiencing housing insecurity isolated from community and belonging. Mike from YSB confirmed this directly, describing the current institutional response as "the antithesis of family and natural supports." This gave us confidence that our 5 Whys had landed in the right place.

Partners valued the concept of the digital platform, but identified accessibility and ethics as the main challenges. People experiencing homelessness lack access to devices and the internet, so the platform works best when a frontline worker uses it alongside someone in the field rather than expecting individuals to navigate it alone. Vanessa from HICC called the concept a "digital navigator" and confirmed it aligns with Reaching Home Directives as a fundable activity. She also described the government's ongoing challenge with achieving a "single window approach".

The feedback channel stood out as a critical, but usually missing idea. Kay called it "fantastic" and said he hadn't seen it widely implemented. Partners cautioned that an unmoderated open channel risks becoming chaotic. One partner shared that a structured model already exists where shelter staff conduct short guided interviews and the data goes to funders. This told us the feedback channel has strong potential but needs to be redesigned.

The community event received the strongest overall endorsement from every partner. Mike emphasized the importance of local champions and storytelling, saying the most effective events humanize the experience through individual stories. Vanessa stressed that events must be community-driven and bottom-up. Kay confirmed that similar awareness events already run successfully in Ottawa and could be replicated in Toronto. One partner shared a real example of a community information session that brought both supporters and opponents into the same room, and by the end, most skeptics had shifted their perspective. The key was framing it as an open conversation rather than a rally, which got people who might otherwise stay away to show up. We drew a comparison between how society's conversations around mental health have shifted over the years and how the same kind of shift could happen for homelessness. One partner mentioned that the idea stuck in their head the whole day across presentations. This idea resonated strongly with partners, who suggested we research how that narrative change actually occurred and apply similar patterns to our event design.

Based on the feedback, we are making four key changes going forward. First, the platform will be redesigned to prioritize frontline provider use alongside individual access. Second, the feedback channel will be restructured from an open forum into a guided, moderated system. Third, the community event will prioritize local champions, partners voices, and getting diverse perspectives into the same room. Fourth, we are connecting both ideas so the event creates face-to-face relationships and the platform sustains them afterward. The event leads, the platform supports.

SOUnd Thinking: Problem Definition

- i) Youth experiencing homelessness in Toronto and Ottawa have access to shelters, transitional housing, and support services — but no pathway that connects those services to

the actual neighbourhoods and communities around them (Segal-Brown, 2024; City of Toronto, 2026). The result is deep isolation — not just from housing, but from the relationships and sense of belonging that make stability last (Rea, 2022). The gap isn't a lack of services. It's that community integration was never built into the system to begin with.

ii) Panel partners and Frontline Respondents gave us valuable real-world perspectives as they worked directly with homelessness. Through conversations during site visits, online meetings, and presentation iterations, we got a deeper understanding of major recurring challenges of underlying stigma, fragmented services, and community disconnection that the vulnerable people, as well as those who support them, face every day.

During the team discussion, we reflected and shared examples of what we had seen, observed, and experienced within our own communities which highlighted the importance of belonging, social support, and awareness rather than just providing more housing. Government reports from Statistics Canada, and the Canadian Human Rights Commission highlighted that the scale of homelessness continues to increase despite the expansion of shelter capacities (Canadian Human Right Commission, 2026). Academic Research on social connections and support networks helped us understand the relationship between social isolation, homelessness, and community belonging. All these sources led the team to investigate homelessness through the lens of community integration and belonging rather than just housing.

iii) The people most directly impacted by this problem are those experiencing housing insecurity, who are frequently cut off from the kinds of social connections and community support that help people stabilize their lives. As Lachaud et al. (2024) found, people who are marginalized by structural systems “feel invisible, powerless and detached from society”. This is not a problem that only affects a certain type of person; financial hardship, health crises, or unexpected life changes can push anyone into housing insecurity. People may make assumptions about those experiencing homelessness that feeds into the stigma. Assumptions like that also colour people's opinions of all those experiencing homelessness, not just who they have experiences with.

That tension is at the heart of what we are trying to address. Our audience is not only people experiencing homelessness but also the everyday community members. Volunteers and local residents can get caught in gaps between services. Service providers and shelters are dealing with their own version of this too, trying to coordinate care within a system that was not built to work together. For example, a shelter may know that a youth needs mental health support, but because there is no shared system connecting them to the right clinic or community program, that referral either gets delayed or never happens at all, leaving the person to fall through the cracks. Community integration matters to our project because all of these pieces are connected. If people do not feel safe or welcome engaging with each other across these divides, no amount of services or resources will actually fix the isolation at the root of the problem.

iv) Through our 5 Whys analysis, we traced the problem from the surface observation that community integration is absent from the homelessness response down to a root cause: homelessness is treated as an individual deficit for professionals to fix rather than a shared community responsibility.

People experiencing housing insecurity lack touchpoints for connection beyond survival services. Social connections in shelters are temporary and peer-only, rarely extending into the neighbourhood (Bower et al., 2022; Gonyea & Melekis, 2019). Services are fragmented across Toronto and Ottawa with little coordination (Lachaud et al., 2024), and the system was built as a top-down emergency response (City of Toronto, 2020). Even existing community hubs like the Keele Community Hub are not designed to connect housing-insecure individuals with local residents (City of Toronto, 2016). Federal spending on homelessness does not include funding for social connection or belonging outcomes (PBO, 2024), and homelessness continues to be framed as an individual problem rather than a community one (Gronda, 2020; Horsell, 2024).

Partners confirmed this. Mike from YSB called the institutional model "the antithesis of family and natural supports." Vanessa from HICC acknowledged the government struggles to connect services to communities. Robert from Better Street said their biggest challenge is NIMBYism, which exists because homelessness has never been framed as something neighbours have a role in solving.

The root cause is a foundational design flaw: community integration was never built into the homelessness response.

v) Our project focuses on the community integration gap between homelessness services and local neighbourhood networks in Toronto and Ottawa.

What's in: an app prototype serving as a digital navigator, a community-driven engagement event framework, and a structured feedback mechanism. The event leads, the platform supports. What's out: housing policy reform, shelter operations, addiction treatment, physical housing, government restructuring, clinical interventions, immigration services, and funding models. These fall outside our community integration theme.

Partners confirmed these boundaries. Mike from YSB said agencies "can't be their parents, can't be their response." Robert from Better Street cautioned that "people will show up expecting help with everything and you only talk about one thing." We are a team of eight in a two-week sprint delivering a prototype and event framework, not a finished product.

vi) It's important to address community integration with the societal problem of homelessness and those experiencing homelessness because of several reasons. Homelessness has been on the rise over the last couple of years. (Parliamentary Budget Officer, 2024). Homelessness has also been driven by cost of living and housing (Statistics Canada, 2023). These align with the literature describing homelessness as not a personal deficit, but instead a wider systemic issue that can impact anyone and impacts the marginalised much more (Horsell, 2024). All people deserve dignity, respect and safety. Choosing to tackle homelessness serves those ideals.

vii) After our site visits, we took some time to discuss with each other what we noticed, such as any gaps or things that align with our root causes. We talked about a lot of things like how the different partners approach solving the many problems regarding homelessness. However, with a lot of thought, we all agreed that one thing stood out to us: the fixed perception of what the problem is. The stigma around homelessness causes the public to believe that the sole problem is one thing, which it's not. Mental and physical health play a

huge role in leading people to face homelessness, which a large percent of society isn't aware of as we learned from our partners.

SOUnd Thinking: Potential Solutions

i) Intended Solutions

After incorporating feedback from our four partner organizations, we are moving forward with one integrated solution combining both kickoff ideas.

Component A — YouBelong: A Frontline-Facing Digital Resource Hub

YouBelong is a locally-run platform built for frontline workers — outreach staff, shelter workers, and case managers — who currently have no single place to find and share community programs, events, and peer support pathways. Rather than expecting housing-insecure individuals to navigate a digital tool themselves, YouBelong works through the trusted workers already in their lives. (See Appendix G for logo and key features.)

Component B — Community Awareness Event

A community walk or event focused on shifting the public narrative around homelessness and non-market housing. It would feature partner booths, local champions, and lived experience stories delivered by partners. We would create a reusable, scalable event outline that any partner can adapt. Drawing on BetterStreet's experience with skeptical community members, the event prioritizes proactive engagement before conflict arises, while preparing partners for difficult conversations. Messaging would be amplified through social media.

ii) Evaluation Criteria

We assessed solutions against three criteria. First, accessibility solutions had to work for people without reliable technology or transportation, supported through trusted frontline workers rather than self-navigation. Second, community impact solutions had to build genuine social connection, given that isolation is a documented barrier to long-term stability (Lachaud et al., 2024). Third, feasibility and sustainability — solutions had to be maintainable by community organizations and transferable across contexts. YouBelong and the community event series best met all three criteria (Wagner, 2022).

iii) Solutions Ruled Out

We initially considered a broad public-facing digital platform with open peer support and a public feedback channel. Partner feedback raised concerns around accessibility, moderation, privacy, and sustainability. Rather than scrapping the idea, we narrowed it to a frontline-worker tool and restructured the feedback channel as a staff-moderated process. Partners were more enthusiastic about the community event as the primary vehicle for public engagement and stigma reduction.

iv) Positive Impacts

Research shows social connection is foundational to housing stability, not secondary to it. Lachaud et al. (2024) found that community-based interventions that build belonging

alongside shelter access produce better long-term outcomes than service-only approaches — a finding confirmed by Mike from YSB, who noted the sector is nationally shifting toward community support models. For YouBelong, the key impacts are reduced time frontline workers spend navigating fragmented resources and a structured feedback channel that gives housing-insecure individuals a voice in shaping local services. Vanessa from HICC validated this as a fundable digital navigator under the Reaching Home Directives (Housing, Infrastructure and Communities Canada, 2026).

For the community event, proactive engagement that brings diverse stakeholders together before conflict arises significantly increases the likelihood of lasting community support (Wagner, 2022). Robert from BetterStreet confirmed this through direct experience, describing how a community session in Ajax successfully shifted perspectives by getting supporters and opponents in the same room. Together, both components shift homelessness from a service delivery problem to a community belonging problem — which is where our research, our 5 Whys, and our partner feedback all converge.

v) Negative Impacts and Mitigation

The platform's biggest risk is the accessibility gap — if built for digitally literate users only, it excludes the most vulnerable. Our mitigation is designing it for frontline workers to use alongside individuals in the field, not as a standalone tool. The feedback channel risks becoming unmoderated and unmanageable; we mitigate this by making it a guided, staff-moderated process with structured questions rather than an open forum. The community event risks preaching to the choir — Robert noted social media awareness typically only reaches existing supporters. We mitigate this by framing events as open information sessions rather than rallies, drawing on local champions like councillors and partners to broaden the audience. Scope creep is also a risk; we mitigate this by clearly defining the platform's scope upfront with partners so expectations are managed. Finally, we recognize the risk of tokenistic engagement with people with lived experience — our mitigation is involving them in the design process from the start, not presenting to them after the fact.

vi) Team Strengths

Our team brought a range of disciplines and experiences — engineering, health, social sciences, urban planning — that gave us multiple lenses on the problem. Members with backgrounds in research, design, and community work each contributed to different stages, from problem definition to solution prototyping to partner engagement. That diversity of perspective is what allowed us to move from a broad problem to a focused, feasible solution.

vii) Process Reflection

We started by grounding ourselves in research on homelessness and social isolation before jumping to solutions. Two ideas emerged — a digital platform and a community event — each tackling the problem from a different angle. The platform came from noticing that resources exist but aren't connected. The event came from recognizing that stigma stops people from helping their neighbours in the first place. Site visits and partner conversations sharpened both ideas significantly. Hearing directly from frontline workers about how much time they waste chasing referrals — time that could go toward building trust with someone — made community integration feel less like an assignment concept and more like the actual point of everything we were trying to do.

Collaboration: Roles and Responsibilities of Team Members

Our approach to collaboration was built around flexibility. We used our team charter early on to identify each other's strengths and areas for growth, which helped us understand who was best suited for which responsibilities. Instead of assigning fixed roles at the start, we let responsibilities emerge based on what each task needed and who was best positioned to take it on. Some roles naturally stayed with the same person throughout the week because they required consistency, such as finance management and technical coordination. Others like presenting, note-taking, and research shifted between members depending on the session. This meant that on any given day, someone might be leading a discussion and the next day they might be the one taking notes. The team agreed early on that no role was owned by one person, and anyone could step in where they were needed. This kept the workload balanced and made sure we weren't dependent on any single member for critical tasks. Going into week 2, our engineering members will lead the app prototype build, our health and social science members will refine the event framework and research backing, and our coordinator and management roles will focus on pulling the final deliverables together for the presentation on Friday.

<u>Team Members (8)</u>	<u>Current Roles → More than 1 Member Had Contributed Through More than 1 Role</u>	<u>Planned Roles for Week 2</u>
Paul	Presenter, Setup and technological coordinator, Organizer/ coordinator, meeting notes, Info obtainer	Event framework lead, Presentation delivery, Researcher
Philip	Manager, Facilitator, Mediator/Motivator, Proofreader/Reviewer, Task outline design, Timekeeper, Info obtainer	Overall coordination, Final report review
Kirti	Finance Manager, Technical and digital coordinator, Motivator, Researcher/ Info obtainer	App prototype support, Finance manager, Researcher, Motivator, Presenter, Full stack developer
Reeya	Organizer/ Coordinator, Presenter, Motivator/ Mediator, Task outline design, meeting notes, Time keeper, Info obtainer	Presentation lead, Process reflection writing, Researcher
Marwa	Note Taker, Motivator, Task outline design	References compilation, Research synthesis, Note Taker, Motivator
Yash	Technical and Digital coordinator, presenter, outline design, Motivator, Researcher/ Info obtainer	App prototype Lead, outline design, Full stack developer, Researcher
Asya	Motivator, Presenter, Researcher/ Info obtainer	Motivator, Presenter, Researcher

Mukhveer	Technical & digital coordinator, Motivator, Info obtainer, Task outline design	App prototype support, Motivator, presenter, Researcher
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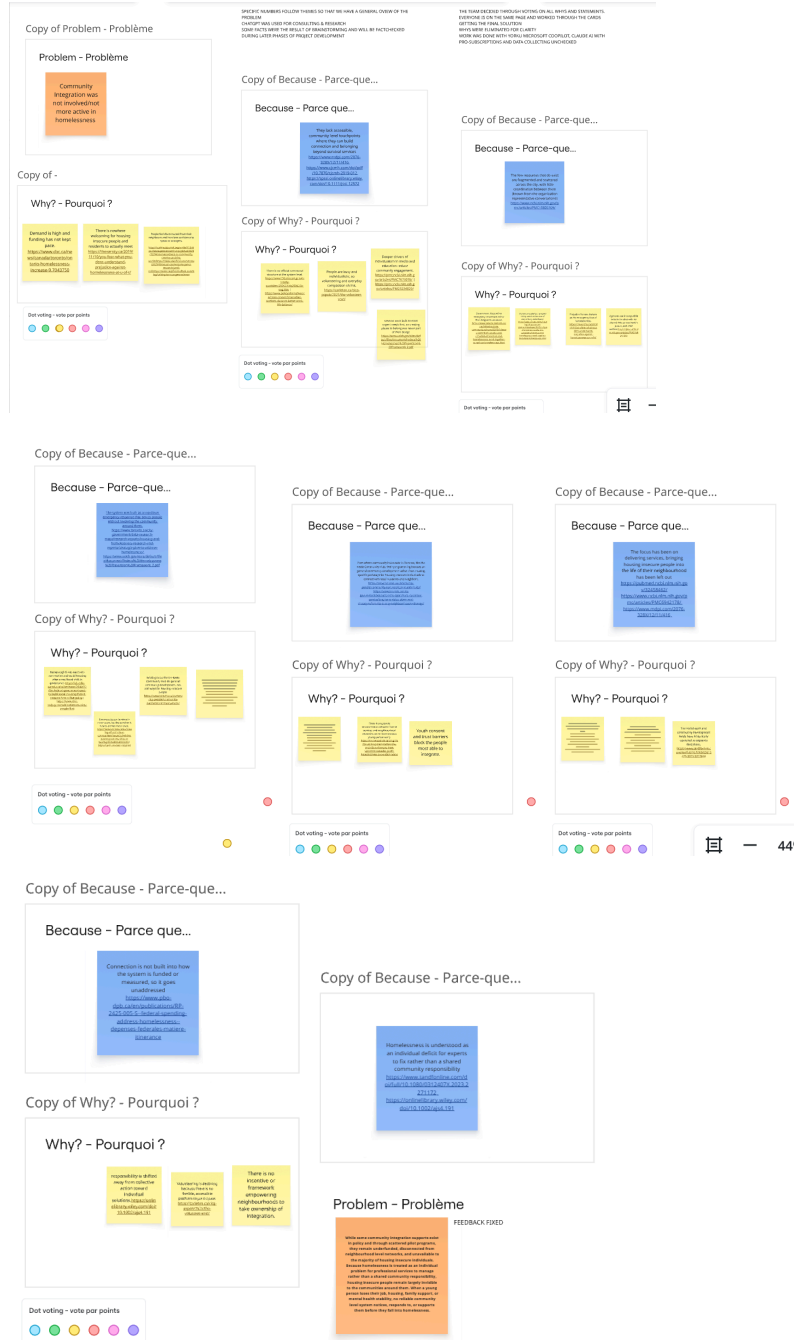
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Appendix

Appendix A – 5 Whys Analysis



The team used 5 Whys analysis exercises to find the potential root causes that drive homelessness and community disconnection. Instead of looking at homelessness as just a housing problem, we got a better understanding of direct or indirect, broader, systematic, and social factors involved.

Appendix B

Partner feedback summary table

YSB	Community support is important, but youth still needs long term meaningful relationships and local champions
Better Street	Reduce scope, avoid Reddit-style feedback, structured navigation is valuable
Trek For Teens	Feedback channel useful, digital access challenges, awareness events effective
HICC	Single-window approach desirable, community-driven education works best

Appendix C

Ethics and privacy considerations

The team found that collecting feedback from vulnerable groups raises important privacy and ethical issues. In the future, it will be necessary to collect data anonymously, get clear consent, and limit who can access sensitive information.

Appendix D

SDG Goals Alignment

The project aligns most closely with SDG 1 (No Poverty), SDG 10 (Reduced Inequalities), SDG 11 (Sustainable Cities and Communities), and SDG 16 (Peace, Justice and Strong Institutions). The proposed community engagement initiatives and navigation support tools aim to improve access to resources, reduce stigma, strengthen community participation, and support vulnerable populations.

Appendix E

Site Visits

Site visits highlighted the importance of community engagement, storytelling, and human-centered approaches to reducing stigma.

Appendix F

Evolution of proposed solution

The initial idea was to build a single large public platform that supports everyone. Partner discussions highlighted concerns about platform accessibility, sustainability, ethical use, and the scope it would address. So, the team narrowed the platform scope to support frontline workers. Partners encouraged the team to combine digital and in-person approaches rather than relying on technology alone.

Appendix G



The platform has three core functions:

- A consolidated resource directory of neighbourhood services, support groups, and community programs updated by participating organizations
- A community connection space where volunteers, frontline workers, and people with lived experience can build relationships beyond transactional service delivery
- An anonymized feedback channel where service users can share what is and isn't working, so their voices directly inform how local services are delivered

The name and brand identity, YouBelong, was developed by the team and received positive feedback from our community partners during the kickoff session.

Appendix H

AI usage statement

AI tools like ChatGPT, Tactiq, Claude were used to help organize meeting notes, synthesize partner feedback, structure report sections, and improve the clarity of written content. All project decisions, interpretations, and final report content were reviewed and edited by team members before submission.